

Situation

Mala: Sir, my brother said he was studying algebra. What is algebra?

Sir: To put it simply, algebra consists of the use of numbers and letters to state and solve problems.

Arun: Does that mean addition and subtraction of letters? How do we do that?

Sir: To prepare for that, let's first learn a few things using numbers.

Equality

Whenever we add, subtract, multiply or divide two numbers, the answer we get is always another number. For example when we add 4 and 2, we get the number 6. We write this as 4 + 2 = 6. Similarly, 10 - 4 =6 , 12 ÷ 2 = 6, 6 x 1 = 6.

Now, let us think about this in another way.

Suppose that, by performing a mathematical operation on two numbers, we have obtained the number 10. Let us find pairs of such numbers.

They could be (5 + 5), (17 - 7), (5 x 2), (20 ÷ 2) etc.

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